

Maslow's Vision for a Psychology of the Peace Table

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Abstract

This essay reinterprets Abraham Maslow not only as a founder of Humanistic and Transpersonal Psychology but as an architect of a third project—an explicitly eupsychian psychology oriented to designing the “good society.” Anchored in Maslow’s pivotal “peace table” vision during World War II, the piece traces how his needs theory and late work (on the “farthest reaches” of human nature) were intended to scaffold a comprehensive framework for human flourishing. It then frames the subsequent marginalization of humanistic/transpersonal currents, what Elkins terms the “loss of power and influence,” as institutional “murder” rather than suicide, and situates it within broader political-economic dynamics that favoured behaviourist, cognitivist, and later positive-psychology paradigms, largely because they are non threatening to the capitalist status quo. Against the backdrop of today’s polycrisis, the essay argues that a Psychology of the Peace Table remains urgently necessary: a collaborative, empirically grounded, and spiritually literate endeavor capable of informing economics, education, health, and civic life. It concludes with a practical call to establish an ongoing Peace Table, initially online, as a working forum where scholars and practitioners can elaborate eupsychian theory, integrate empirical and “mystical” insights, and prototype institutions oriented to connection, autonomy, and species-level flourishing.

Keywords: *Maslow; Eupsychia; Humanistic Psychology; Transpersonal Psychology; Peace Table; Comprehensive Framework; Polycrisis; Human Development; Human Flourishing.*

For those of you who don't know, psychologist [Abraham Maslow](#) was an intellectual and theoretical giant. He was the founding contributor of not one but two powerful new branches of Western Psychology, [Humanistic Psychology](#) and [Transpersonal Psychology](#).

And that's not all.

He put into place theoretical and empirical foundations that he hoped would provide the path forward to a third new psychology, and advanced utopian psychology, a [Eupsychian Psychology](#), aimed at creating the "good society", a society capable of creating happy, healthy, autonomous, and advanced human beings. A society capable of actuating full [Human Potential](#) and engaging full [Human Flourishing](#).

Surprising?

Not really. Maslow wasn't the first founding father to try and push the world in a Utopian direction. Like [August Comte](#), evangelist of empirical verification and founding father of Sociology, set out an entirely new [Religion of Humanity](#), a **universal religion** which he hoped would bring unity and shared purpose to humanity (Comte 1852). Like Comte's Religion of Humanity, Maslow's Eupsychian project is not just a tweak to method but an attempted [Comprehensive Framework](#) for social order.

Ambitious?

Definitely so. All Maslow had to work with at the time were Freudian and Behavioural psychology. To be frank, these were useless for what he wanted to do. He had to build supporting conceptual, theoretical, and research frameworks from scratch (without even a personal computer), and that's what he did, leap-frogging over extant theories and establishing a firm foundation for future development. The scope of his achievement is mind-boggling.

Visionary?

Absolutely! It all started, as it often does, with actual and authentic vision, experienced while he was driving home one day. As he recalled:

One day just after Pearl Harbor, I was driving home and my car was stopped by a poor, pathetic parade. Boy Scouts and fat people and old uniforms and a flag and someone playing a flute off-key. As I watched, the tears began to run down my face. I felt we didn't understand—not Hitler, nor the Germans, nor Stalin, nor the Communists. We didn't understand any of them. I felt that if we could understand, then we could make progress. **I had a vision of a peace table**, with people sitting around it, talking about human nature and hatred and war and peace and brotherhood... That moment changed my whole life." (As quoted in Hoffman 1999:148–49: emphasis added)

As Maslow himself admits, this visionary experience changed his life. It redirected his work. He went from talking about dominance, sex, and motivation in apes to setting down a theory of human needs that he knew would become the root of a groundbreaking [Eupsychian Psychology](#) aimed at creating the conditions for the health and happiness of the entire human species (Maslow 1961a). Not to put too fine a point on it, rather than contributing to the machinery of war, he committed himself to developing what he called a Psychology for the Peace Table, a psychology rooted not in pathology (Freudianism), control (Behaviourism), and adjustment to a highly toxic society (Maslow 1961b), but in understanding the human so as to facilitate healing and full actualization of not only the individual self, but of the entire species.

Amazing?

Indeed he was. Maslow would spend his entire career attempting to build that psychology, and his contributions, as already intimated, were massive. He helped found the *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* in 1961 to serve as a platform for exploring these alternative, growth-oriented views of human nature (Bugental 1964). He helped found the *Journal of Transpersonal Psychology* in 1969, to explore the “Farthest Reaches of Human Nature” (Maslow 1969) i.e., the spiritual, mystical, and transcendent dimensions of the human experience. The culmination of these efforts was the nascent emergence of a Eupsychian Psychology, a psychology that would not only help resacralize an arid and dehumanized science (Maslow 1966; Sutich 1961, 1976), but would also specify exactly how to grow healthy, strong, whole, autonomous, fully

functioning human beings. It would all be grounded in a [Eupsychian Theory](#) that would contribute, according to Maslow, to a reconceptualization of “every area of human knowledge: e.g., economics, sociology, biology, and every profession: e.g., the family, education, religion, etc.” (Maslow 1970:x) and provide new systems of meaning where religion had so thoroughly failed (Maslow 1964)

What Else Can I Say?

Maslow’s contribution was stunning. In just a little over two decades Maslow went from visionary experience to actual implementation. In 1969 he wrote that, “There is now available a new conception, of a higher possibility, of the healthy society. There are tools now available to judge and compare societies. One society can be judged to be better than another society, or healthier or possessing more ‘growth-fostering-potential.’ We can talk about the value of the society, or the function of the society-that is, the greatest coming to fulfillment of the people in the society” (Maslow 1969:7).

It is worthwhile reviewing the preceding paragraph. Maslow felt he had accomplished what he set out to do, build a Psychology for the Peace table. Of course, he didn’t do it alone and he wasn’t anywhere near finished, but it was his vision from the start. He was also very clear that the work that he and others had done by 1970 was only the “bare beginning” (Maslow 1970:xxi); nevertheless progress had been made.

Tragically, Maslow’s vision was never fully realized. He died prematurely in 1970, at the age of 62. But more than that, as Elkins (2009) documents, the broader humanistic project that Maslow helped inaugurate was aggressively marginalized and systematically defunded. I am an eyewitness to this assassination. In the fourth year of my undergraduate psychology degree (circa 1985), all the humanistic, transpersonal, and existential psychologists in my small department were retired and replaced with behaviourists, cognitive-behaviourists and, later, the positive psychology offered by the establishment today.

Note, it is crucial to clarify that when I use the metaphor of “murder,” I am not alleging a secret, coordinated conspiracy in the cloak-and-dagger sense. Rather, as the evidence in Elkins’s article

show, I am describing a socio-political and academic process of systematic marginalization that was public, multifaceted, and intentional. This process was driven by what Elkins called “destructive forces” (Elkins, 2009, p. 271) but what I would call an [Accumulating Class](#) intent on preserving their exploitative status quo. These forces operated not in shadowy secrecy, but through visible channels: the "virulent attack from right-wing and reactionary groups" that Carl Rogers documented as early as 1970 (as cited in Elkins, 2009, p. 273); the "negative stereotypes" perpetuated in mainstream journals (Elkins, 2009, p. 279); and the institutional "failing to acknowledge the scholarly contributions of humanistic psychology" by influential figures (Elkins, 2009, p. 280). The "death" of humanistic psychology's influence was the result of this "coordinated campaign" of opposition (Elkins, 2009, p. 286), not a natural death due to inherent flaws. To understand this not as a conspiracy theory but as a documented historical conflict, one need only look to the "fundamental divide" and "radical conflict" between the assumptions of humanistic psychology and the "basic assumptions and values of contemporary mainstream psychology" (Elkins, 2009, p. 284) and capitalist society. The metaphor of murder is used here to starkly refute the notion of suicide and to correctly assign agency for this decline to these powerful, external actors.

Whatever the reason for Humanistic Psychology’s decline, it was gone in an instant. Its emancipatory, truth-seeking, growth-affirming, revolutionary impulse effectively erased. It still exists, of course, and still has some influence (DeRobertis 2013), but, I would argue in a castrated and caricatured (Sosteric and Ratkovic 2020) form.

It’s shocking when you think about it, particularly where you consider where we might be now, empirically and theoretically, if Humanistic and Transpersonal Psychology had been properly supported to grow.

As the proverb goes, no sense crying over spilt milk. Was geschehen ist, ist geschehen. *Omi tó tán lóri ilè kò lè jònà* 覆水盆に返らず . गया वक्त वापस नहीं आता

The past is past.

It is a waste to spend too much energy there.

So what are we going to do?

Well, we have to do something. The inadequacies of our existing philosophical, methodological, and ideological systems has never been clearer. The need for a Psychology of the Peace Table has never been more pressing. The world is facing a polycrisis (Albert 2024). If we don't do something, things are going to keep getting worse.

Therefore, I propose we establish Maslow's Peace Table, right here, right now, initially [in this online space](#) but expanding as we go. Here we (scholars, writers, professionals) can start talking openly about the things we need to know, the things we need to do, and the things we need to make (new institutions, etc.) in order to create healthy, happy humans capable of manifesting Maslow's Eupsychia. We can root this in Maslow's seminal work (and the work of others like Comte, Fromm, Grof, Rogers, Horney, and May, etc.), but we can move beyond with our own empirical, theoretical, and even "mystical" insights (Sosteric 2022), together building the new system that Maslow wanted to build and doing it with full, transformative intent.

We, and by "we" I mean the human species, are about to lose everything we've worked for.

What else are we going to do?

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